"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 33

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

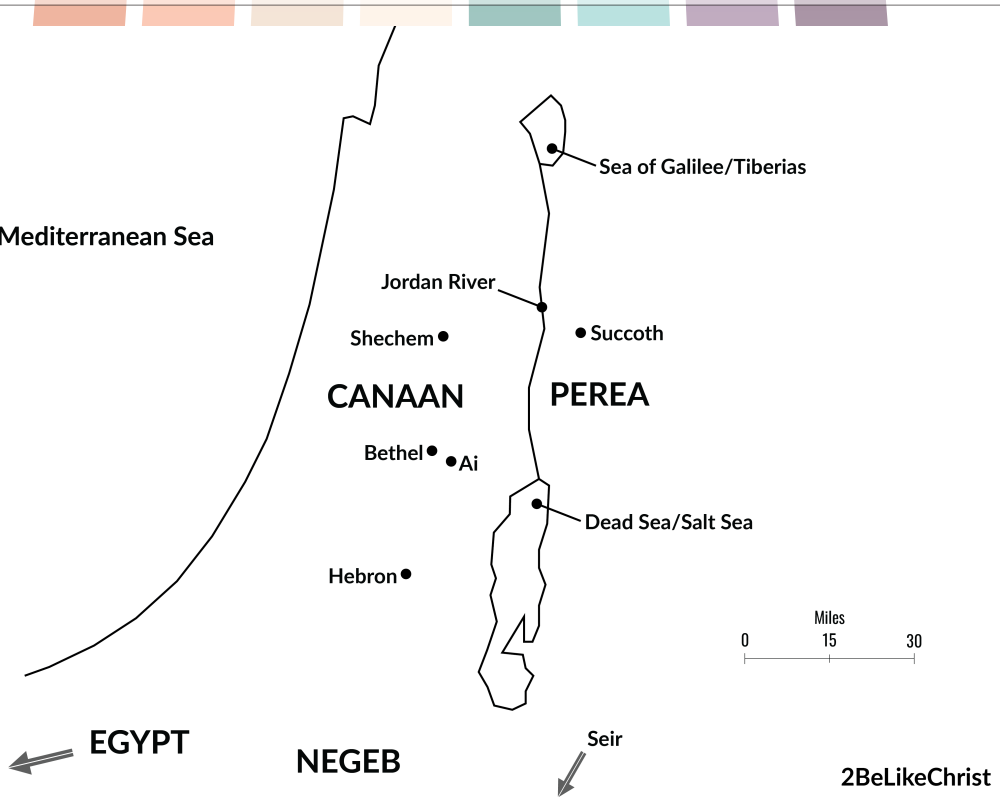
- The exact date of Jacob's return to Canaan is not known, but using information throughout Genesis, it seems likely it occurred between 1745-1725 B.C.

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac and Rebekah and twin brother of Esau. He lived in Haran for 20 years after deceiving his father and stealing from his brother.
- Esau – Jacob's brother who he hadn't seen in 20 years. Esau was planning to kill Jacob the last time they were in each other's presence (27:41).

Where:

- Jacob lived in Haran for 20 years but returned to Canaan in Genesis 31-33.
- Esau lived in Seir, which was in the country of Edom (32:3).
- After reuniting with Esau, Jacob lived in Succoth and Shechem.



Outline:

- JACOB REUNITIES WITH ESAU AFTER 20 YEARS (33:1-11):
    + After being blessed by God in Genesis 32 and having his name changed to Israel, Jacob looked up and saw Esau approaching with 400 men.
    + Fearing Esau might still hate him after their 20-year separation, Jacob divided his family into groups, with Rachel and Joseph at the back.
    + He went ahead of his wives and children and bowed to Esau 7 times.
    + Esau ran towards his brother, embraced him, and kissed him and the brothers cried together on account of their happy reunion.
    + Jacob introduced his family and his household to Esau, and they all approached and bowed.
    + Esau tried to return the gift Jacob had sent him (32:14-15) because he was already a wealthy man, but Jacob insisted he keep it.
- THE JOURNEY TO SEIR (33:12-20):
    + After reuniting, Esau invited Jacob to his home in Seir.
    + Jacob told Esau to go ahead of him. He needed to travel slowly because of the animals and children in his company.
    + Jacob journeyed to Succoth and built a house and shelter for his livestock.
    + Later, Jacob went to Shechem and purchased a piece of land from the sons of Hamor on which to erect his tent.
    + He built an altar at his camp and called it El-Elohe-Israel.

Application:

- Forgiveness will bring peace to your soul and resolution to your problems.
- Esau could have held a grudge against his brother for 20 years and refused to forgive him, but that would have been toxic to his soul, and it would have brought war to his house upon Jacob's return.
- We harm no one more than ourselves when we withhold forgiveness from those who genuinely ask.
- We forgive people in light of the forgiveness we've receive from God, through Jesus.
- The more we appreciate God's forgiveness, the quicker we'll extend forgiveness to others.